

Tritheism Denial

doc-tritheism-denial

Theology Proper · Trinity · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

The three Persons of the Trinity share one divine essence; they are not three separate gods.

In plain language

The Hebrew Bible repeatedly says God is one, but the word one is not the whole argument. Deuteronomy 6:4 puts 'the LORD' (YHWH, יהוה) together with the cardinal number 'one' (echad, אחד) in predicate position (the slot completing an 'X is Y' statement), 'the LORD our God is one'. Yet the same Hebrew word for one ('echad') also describes a husband and wife becoming one flesh in Genesis 2:24 and a crowd acting as one people in Genesis 11:6, so by itself the number one can describe a unity that still contains more than one part. The real force against three gods comes from the exclusivity words (small Hebrew words meaning 'no other' or 'besides'). Isaiah 45:5 stacks several small particles meaning no, none, no other, besides me ('there is none' (ayin), 'not' (lo), 'besides' (zulah), 'still' (od)). Isaiah 44:6 adds 'first and last and besides me there is no god', using a second rare word for besides ('biladey'). Deuteronomy 4:35 repeats 'no other besides him'. These words flatly deny that any other god exists alongside 'the LORD' (YHWH), which is exactly what rules out three separate gods. The New Testament keeps this count. In Mark 12:29 Jesus quotes the Shema (the daily Jewish confession) and uses the Greek number 'one' ('heis') of God, and in 1 Corinthians 8:4 Paul writes there is no God except one. Then in 1 Corinthians 8:6 Paul takes that one confession and names 'one God the Father' ('heis theos ho pater') and 'one Lord Jesus Christ' ('heis kyrios') inside it, with the words 'from whom' and 'through whom' mapping creation to both. He does not produce two gods. He places Father and Son within the single deity. Matthew 28:19 keeps the same balance, using a singular word 'name' ('onoma') over three distinct named Persons, which blocks both three gods and a collapse into one Person. The seam that lets readers diverge is the number one, since it can mean either a bare single unit or a composite unity. The exclusivity particles settle the question against three gods, while the distinct named Persons inside the one confession keep the persons from being erased. The lexical pattern supports the proposition that the three Persons are one God and not three separate gods.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אחד	echad	one	944
H0314	אחרון	acharon	last	
H0369	אין	ayin	nothing	720
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	2,602
H0589	אני	ani	I	
H0905	בד	bad	alone	

H1107	בְּלֶעַד	biladey	beside	16
H2108	זוּלָּה	zulah	exception	13
H3045	יָדָעַ	yada	to know	
H3068	יְהוָה	YHWH	LORD	6,828
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H5750	עוֹד	od	still	456
G0235	ἀλλά	alla	but	
G1223	διὰ	dia	through/because of	
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2962	κύριος	kurios	lord	
G3762	οὐδεὶς	oudeis	none	
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	426
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	581

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The Bible applies the cardinal number 'one' directly to God: 'one' (echad, אחד) in the Shema (the daily Jewish confession at Deuteronomy 6:4, which the Hebrew syntax database ETCBC tags as the predicate complement, PreC, that is, the word completing the 'is' statement), and 'one God' (heis theos, εἷς θεός) in the apostolic restatement at 1 Corinthians 8:6 and Mark 12:29. The canon then forecloses any rival deity by stacking exclusivity particles, that is, small Hebrew words that mean 'there is none', 'not', 'except', 'besides me', 'no other': 'there is none' (ayin, אין), 'not' (lo, לא), 'besides' (zulah, זוּלָּה), 'apart from me' (biladey, בְּלֶעַד), and 'still, any more' (od, עוֹד), across Deuteronomy 4:35, Isaiah 44:6, and Isaiah 45:5. The number 'one' (echad, אחד) by itself is not decisive because it also names a composite unity (one flesh in Genesis 2:24, one people in Genesis 11:6), so the weight against three gods rests on the exclusivity formulas that deny any other God beside YHWH (the covenant name of God, YHWH, יְהוָה). Within that single confession Paul distributes 'one God the Father' (heis theos ho pater, εἷς θεὸς ὁ πατήρ) and 'one Lord Jesus Christ' (heis kyrios Iesous Christos, εἷς κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός), placing Father and Son inside the one God rather than alongside it as a second deity. The pattern spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical) denies a plurality of separate gods while preserving personal distinction, which is the substance of the proposition under test.

Scripture

Deut.6.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0430 אלהים, H0259 אחד.

Reasoning. The Shema (the daily Jewish confession that begins 'Hear, O Israel') couples the covenant name 'the LORD' (YHWH, יהוה) with the cardinal number 'one' (echad, אחד) in predicate position (the slot completing an 'X is Y' statement), asserting that 'the LORD' (YHWH) our God is 'one' (echad). The Hebrew syntax database ETCBC tags the clause as a quoted statement (Q) with 'one' (echad, אחד) marked as PreC (the predicate, that is, the noun completing the 'is' statement), and 'the LORD' (YHWH, יהוה) as the grammatical subject (Subj). The number is the ordinary cardinal 'one'. By itself 'one' (echad, אחד) can frame composite unity (one flesh in Genesis 2:24, one people in Genesis 11:6, queried and confirmed), so the verse establishes a singular count of the one God but leaves the foreclosure of rival gods to the exclusivity particles (small Hebrew words denying any other) in the parallel texts.

Isa.45.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0369 אין, H0589 אני, H2108 זולה, H3808 לא, H5750 עוד

Reasoning. The LORD's first-person self-declaration stacks negation and exclusivity particles (small words that deny and exclude). 'I am the LORD and there is no other' (ani YHWH ve-eyn od, אני יהוה ואין עוד) affirms 'I am the LORD' (YHWH) and 'there is no other', then 'and there is none besides me' (ve-eyn zulah, ...ואין זולתי) excludes any besides him, with 'not' (lo, לא) reinforcing the negation. The Hebrew syntax database ETCBC marks the negations as Nega (negation) and NCop (negative copula, that is, a negated linking verb) and the exclusivity term as Modi (modifier) or Adju (adjunct, that is, an added qualifier), syntactically denying the existence of any other God. The combination of 'there is none' (ayin, אין) plus 'still, any more' (od, עוד) plus 'besides' (zulah, זולה) is the lexical engine that rules out a plurality of gods.

Isa.44.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0369 אין, H0314 אחרון, H1107 בלעדי.

Reasoning. Queried token set confirms 'there is none' (ayin, אין, H0369), 'last' (acharon, אחרון, H0314), and 'besides me' (biladey, בלעדי, H1107). 'The LORD' (YHWH) declares himself the first and the last and that besides him there is no god. 'Apart from me' (biladey, בלעדי) is a parallel exclusivity term to 'besides' (zulah, זולה). Each is rare, 16 and 13 occurrences in the whole Bible respectively, and both function the same way, denying any deity apart from 'the LORD' (YHWH). This adds a second independent exclusivity word to the same pattern, strengthening the canonical denial of other gods.

1Cor.8.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G2316 θεός, G3962 πατήρ, G5547 Χριστός, G0235 ἀλλά

Reasoning. Paul places 'one God the Father' (heis theos ho pater, εἷς θεὸς ὁ πατήρ) and 'one Lord Jesus Christ' (heis kyrios Iesous Christos, εἷς κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός) in a single contrast clause introduced by 'but to us' (all' hemin, ἀλλ' ἡμῖν). The numeral 'one' (heis, εἷς), which is queried as present in this verse, governs both 'God' (theos, θεός) and 'Lord' (kyrios, κύριος) in parallel without producing two gods, because the Father and Christ are distributed across the elements of the Shema (the Greek 'the Father' (ho pater, ὁ πατήρ) aligns with 'God' (theos, θεός), and 'the Lord Jesus Christ' (ho kyrios Iesous Christos, ὁ κύριος Ἰησοῦς Χριστός) aligns with 'Lord' (kyrios, κύριος)). The prepositions 'from whom' (ex hou, ἐξ οὗ) and 'through whom' (di' hou, δι' οὗ) map creation to both, holding them within one source rather than tallying two deities.

Deut.4.35 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H0369 אין, H5750 עוד, H3045 ידע.

Reasoning. Parallel monotheistic formula (a formula that affirms one God). Queried token set confirms 'there is none' (ayin, אין, H0369) and 'still, any more' (od, עוד, H5750) in this verse. 'The LORD is the God; there is no other besides him' (YHWH hu ha-Elohim eyn od mi-levado, יהוה הוא־האלהים אין עוד מלבדו) states that 'the LORD' (YHWH) is the God, there is no other besides him. The same pair 'there is none' (ayin, אין) and 'any more' (od, עוד) found in Isaiah 45:5 anchors a single canonical lexical pattern of exclusive deity in the Torah (the first five books of Moses), linked by cross-reference to the Shema in the next chapter.

1Cor.8.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G2316 θεός, G1520 εἷς

Reasoning. Immediate context to 1 Corinthians 8:6, with 'one' (heis, εἷς) queried as present here as well. Paul affirms 'no God except one' (oudeis theos ei me heis, οὐδεὶς θεὸς εἰ μὴ εἷς). This sets the number 'one' as the controlling count for the deity word 'God' (theos, θεός) before he distributes Father and Son inside that one in verse 6, the Greek mirror of the Hebrew exclusivity formulas.

Mark.12.29 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2962 κύριος, G2316 θεός, G1520 εἷς

Reasoning. Jesus cites the Shema (the daily Jewish confession) in Greek, 'the Lord our God, the Lord is one' (kyrios ho theos hemon kyrios heis estin, κύριος ὁ θεὸς ἡμῶν κύριος εἷς ἐστίν), with 'one' (heis, εἷς) and 'God' (theos, θεός) queried as present. Jesus himself anchors the one-God confession with the same number 'one' (heis, εἷς) used in 1 Corinthians 8:6, demonstrating canonical continuity of the lexical pattern from Torah (the first five books of Moses) to Gospels and confirming that the count of one is carried, not abandoned, in the New Testament.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.6.4	Deut.4.35	tsk	1
Isa.45.5	Isa.45.14	tsk	1
Isa.45.5	Isa.22.21	tsk	1
1Cor.8.6	1Cor.8.4	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.2.24 · addressed

The same number 'one' (echad, אחד) used of God in Deuteronomy 6:4 names a composite unity here (man and wife become 'one flesh', basar echad, בשר־אחד), queried and confirmed alongside Genesis 11:6 (one people) and Ezekiel 37:17 (two sticks become one). This means the bare number 'one' does not by itself foreclose plurality, which is why the verdict rests on the exclusivity particles (small Hebrew words denying any other: 'there is none' (ayin, אין), 'besides' (zulah, זולה), 'apart from me' (biladey, בלעדי), 'still, any more' (od, עוד)) rather than on the count word alone. This is the genuine lexical seam (the point where the words allow more than one reading) that both rival readings press.

Gen.1.26 · addressed

The first-person plural cohortative 'let us make' (na'aseh, נַעֲשֶׂה) (a Hebrew verb form expressing 'let us do something') appears with the singular subject 'God' (Elohim, אֱלֹהִים) and produces a singular outcome in verse 27 ('and he created', va-yivra, וַיִּבְרָא, singular). The plural verb form does not yield plural gods. The same pattern recurs in Genesis 11:7 and Isaiah 6:8 without dissolving the canonical monotheism (the affirmation of one God) affirmed in Deuteronomy 6:4 and Isaiah 45:5.

Ps.82.1 · addressed

'God' (Elohim, אֱלֹהִים) in the assembly of 'God' (El, אֵל) is judicial language for human or angelic rulers (compare the citation in John 10:34 explaining these are those to whom the word of God came). The Hebrew word 'God' (Elohim, אֱלֹהִים) has broader semantic range (a wider span of possible meanings) than the count noun 'god' in English and does not contradict the singular number 'one' (echad, אחד) applied to 'the LORD' (YHWH, יְהוָה).

Matt.28.19 · addressed

The triadic baptismal formula (the three-part baptism wording) uses the singular 'name' (onoma, ὄνομα, name, not 'names') governing three articulated genitives (three nouns each carrying 'the' and standing in the 'of-X' grammatical form). The lexical singular of 'name' (onoma, ὄνομα) prevents reading three separate deities, while the three distinct articulated Persons prevent reduction to one Person. This matches the one essence with personal distinction grammar implied by 1 Corinthians 8:6.

John.10.30 · addressed

'I and the Father, we are one' (ego kai ho pater hen esmen, ἐγὼ καὶ ὁ πατήρ ἓν ἐσμεν) uses the neuter 'one' (hen, ἓν, meaning 'one thing', neuter gender) with the plural verb 'we are' (esmen, ἐσμεν). The neuter number signals unity of essence or action rather than collapse of Persons. This lexical choice corroborates rather than contradicts the divine unity affirmed in the Shema (the daily Jewish confession).

Concordance traversed

H0259, H0369, H3808, H2108, H1107, H5750, H3068, H0430, H0905, G1520, G2316, G3962, G5547, G2962, G3762, G0235, G1223, G1519, G1537

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Deuteronomy 6:4, Deuteronomy 4:35, Isaiah 44:6, and Isaiah 45:5 are Hebrew text with stable witness in the Westminster Leningrad Codex (WLC) and the Eep Talstra Centre for Bible and Computer Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia Amstelodamensis (ETCBC-BHSA), and the Old Testament is not in the scope of the ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants). 1 Corinthians 8:4 to 8:6 and Mark 12:29 have no significant variation affecting 'one God' (heis theos, εἷς θεός) or 'one Lord' (heis kyrios, εἷς κύριος) in the queried token set, and not_in_ecm_scope is true for this bundle.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenantal_monotheism, shema_reformulation

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenantal_monotheism: supports · Reads Deuteronomy 6:4 as a covenantal oath of exclusive allegiance to one 'LORD' (YHWH, יְהוָה), with prophetic restatements (Isaiah 44:6, Isaiah 45:5) and apostolic reformulation (1 Corinthians 8:6, Mark 12:29) preserving the count of one God across covenants. The exclusivity particles (small words denying any other God) 'there is none' (ayin, אֵין), 'besides' (zulah, זָלָה), 'apart from me' (biladey, בִּלְעַדִּי), and 'still, any more' (od, עוֹד) carry the denial of rival gods.

shema_reformulation: supports · Treats 1 Corinthians 8:6 as a christological expansion (an expansion focused on Christ) of Deuteronomy 6:4 where 'Lord' (kyrios, κύριος) and 'God' (theos, θεός) are split across Father and Son without multiplying the count, yielding divine unity with personal distinction inside the one-God confession.

tritheist_reading: complicates · Its strongest lexical case leans on the plural noun 'God' (Elohim, אֱלֹהִים) (a Hebrew noun with plural form), the plural cohortative 'let us make' (na'aseh, נַעֲשֶׂה) at Genesis 1:26 (a 'let us' form), and the distinct articulated Persons ('the Father' (ho pater, ὁ πατήρ), 'the Lord Jesus' (ho kyrios Iesous, ὁ κύριος Ἰησοῦς), the third in Matthew 28:19) to argue for more than one divine being. The lexical data answers it directly. The exclusivity particles 'there is no other' (ayin od, אֵין עוֹד) and 'besides' (zulah, זָלָה) and 'apart from me' (biladey, בִּלְעַדִּי) deny any God besides 'the LORD' (YHWH, יְהוָה), the 'let us make' (na'aseh, נַעֲשֶׂה) still yields a singular verb

in Genesis 1:27, and 1 Corinthians 8:6 holds Father and Son inside one 'one God' (heis theos, εἷς θεός), so the words foreclose three separate gods.

strict_unitarian_reading: partially_complicates · Its strongest lexical case reads 'one' (echad, אחד) and 'one God' (heis theos, εἷς θεός) as numerically excluding any distinct person within the deity, treating the Father alone as God. The lexical data tempers this by noting that 1 Corinthians 8:6 itself distributes 'one' (heis, εἷς) across Father and Son in the same one-confession, Mark 12:29 in Jesus' own mouth keeps the count, and Matthew 28:19 keeps the singular 'name' (onoma, ὄνομα) over three Persons, so the count of one constrains the number of gods, not the recognition of distinct Persons.

The verdict turns on two lexical facts held together. First, the cardinal number 'one' (echad, אחד; heis, εἷς) is predicated of God, but that number alone also frames composite unity (Genesis 2:24), so it is not decisive on its own. Second, the exclusivity particles (small denying and excluding words) 'there is none' (ayin, אין), 'not' (lo, לא), 'besides' (zulah, זולא), 'apart from me' (biladey, בלעדֵי), and 'still, any more' (od, עוד) deny any other God, which is what forecloses tritheism (the view that there are three separate gods). Personal distinction is signaled by separate articulated nouns ('the Father' (ho pater, ὁ πατήρ), 'the Lord Jesus' (ho kyrios Iesous, ὁ κύριος Ἰησοῦς)) and the triadic formula (three-part formula) governed by the singular 'name' (onoma, ὄνομα).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The three Persons are one God, not three separate gods; within the one divine being the Father, Son, and Spirit are distinct yet are not three deities.

The proposition is a denial stem that encodes its own conclusion (tritheism, the view that there are three separate gods, is false). The phrase 'three Persons and one divine essence' is post-biblical creedal vocabulary (the technical Greek and Latin words 'being' (ousia), 'individual subsistence' (hypostasis), and 'person' (persona) developed by the early church) not found verbatim in the canon. The lexical evidence supports the substance of the claim using biblical categories. The number 'one' (echad, אחד) and 'one' (heis, εἷς) applied to God, the exclusivity particles (small denying words) denying any other God, and the distinct articulated 'Father' (ho pater, ὁ πατήρ), 'Son', and 'Spirit' held inside the one confession. The verdict was derived on the original stem. The neutralized form restates the same claim without the technical Trinitarian vocabulary so a reader outside that tradition can still see what is affirmed and what is denied.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.6.4
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.45.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.44.6
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0259
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0369
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2108
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1107
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1520
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2316
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.8.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.12.29
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.8.6
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Deut.6.4
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